

How Many Trucks and Movers Do You Actually Need to Start?

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The instinct when starting a moving company is to have enough capacity to never say no. Buy 2 or 3 trucks, hire a full crew, build out before the demand arrives.

This is backwards. And it's one of the most common reasons new moving companies struggle in year one.

The Minimum Viable Moving Operation

1 truck + 2 movers is a legitimate, profitable business.

One 24-foot box truck with a 2-person crew can complete:

- 1 to 2 local residential moves per day
- 8 to 12 moves per week at full utilization
- \$6,000 to \$12,000+ per week in revenue

That's \$24,000 to \$48,000 per month from one truck. Before adding another truck, prove you can fill the first one consistently.

Starting as Owner-Operator

Most successful moving company owners started by being one of the two movers.

The advantages:

- Dramatically lowers your labor cost early on (you're working, not just managing)
- You learn the operations from inside the job
- You can be selective about which days you work while building volume
- Your job quality is directly in your control on every move

The tradeoff:

- You can't scale beyond a certain point while you're physically on the truck
- Eventually you need to hire someone to replace yourself

This is a fine starting position. Work it for the first 3 to 6 months while you build volume and systems. Then hire a crew lead who can run jobs independently and step off the truck.

When to Hire Movers

Before your first job: You need at least one reliable helper on day one. Moving is a 2-person minimum job for almost every residential move.

Options:

- **W-2 employee:** More commitment, more administrative overhead, but builds loyalty and team culture
- **1099 contractors:** More flexibility, less overhead, but higher turnover and inconsistency risk
- **Labor marketplace (Dolly, TaskRabbit, moving helper platforms):** On-demand labor that you can scale up and down. Higher cost per hour but zero

commitment. Good for validating demand before committing to employees.

Most operators start with a combination: 1 reliable hired mover as a part-time employee for regular jobs, supplemented with on-demand labor for overflow.

The Right Truck Count for Your Stage

Stage	Trucks	Movers	When to Move to Next Stage
Validation	1	2 (including you)	70%+ utilization for 6 weeks
Building	1	2 to 3 (you managing)	80%+ utilization, turning away 5+ jobs/month
Scaling	2	4 to 6	75%+ utilization across both trucks
Growth	3 to 5	8 to 15	Consistent demand, dispatcher hired

Notice: you move to the next stage when utilization proves demand, not in anticipation of demand.

The Crew Quality Problem

For moving companies specifically, crew quality matters more than almost any other factor in the business. One mover who:

- Shows up late to a job
- Handles furniture carelessly
- Is rude to a customer
- No-shows without warning

...can generate a 1-star review that follows your company for years.

Starting small (1 truck, 2 movers) lets you be very selective about crew. You can personally train and supervise. You can screen thoroughly and let people go who don't meet your standards.

Operators who scale crew too quickly before establishing quality standards end up with inconsistent service, high claims, bad reviews, and high turnover — a compounding problem that's much harder to fix than it was to prevent.

The Equipment You Need Day One

Beyond the truck, here's what every move requires:

Equipment	Minimum Quantity	Cost
Moving blankets	12 to 24	\$80 – \$200
Furniture dollies	2	\$30 – \$60 each
Appliance dolly	1	\$80 – \$200
Stair-climbing dolly	1	\$200 – \$400
Moving straps	4 sets	\$20 – \$40/set
Stretch wrap	3 to 4 rolls	\$30 – \$60
Floor runners	2 to 3	\$50 – \$150
Door frame protection	2 sets	\$50 – \$100
Disassembly toolkit	1	\$100 – \$300

Total: \$1,000 to \$1,800 for a properly equipped truck.

Don't show up without this. Customers who see a truck arrive without proper equipment get nervous — and right to. Equipment shortfalls lead to damage, which leads to claims and bad reviews.

Want to understand what a single truck can generate in your specific market?

Book a free strategy call and we'll model it out.